



THE SECOND QUEEN: Plush interiors of the Heritage on Wheels

Express Exotica

A luxury train, on the lines of Palace on Wheels, targets the well-heeled domestic tourist

■ By Rohit Parihar

Move over Palace on Wheels. The Heritage on Wheels is here to give it a run for its money. Inspired by the success of their first luxury train, the Rajasthan Tourism Development Corporation (RTDC) and the Indian Railways launched a second train two years back en route to the unexplored regions of Shekhawati. At less than half the per day cost of a seven-day trip on the Palace, one can enjoy an equally adventurous and luxurious three-day journey on this train.

Initially launched to take some load off the Palace, this train has become more popular among the domestic tourists who have had enough of flying to Malaysia and Bangkok. With plummeting cost of air travel, more and more people are now willing to spend even on home travel. To cash in on this, RTDC recently announced special packages for the train. Its latest journey, through December 31 and ending with the dawn of the new year, had all Indians—68—in its first-ever chartered booking.

Mukesh Jagga, director, Viva Holidays and president of the Association of Domestic Tour Operators of India says for domestic tourists who thought the Palace on Wheel was out of bounds, the Heritage on Wheels comes as a crispy and



unique luxurious experience of Rajasthan's culture. Manu and Rajeev Verma of Chandigarh shelled out an all-inclusive Rs 66,000 for a trip on the train along with their two kids. "I do not remember when I last travelled by train with my family," says Verma who runs a rice mill. It was keeping such tourists in mind that RTDC changed its itiner-

ary, from Jaipur-Bikaner-Shekhawati to Jaipur, Shekhawati and then Bikaner, covering on the way places such as Black Buck Sanctuary at Tal Chappar, Mandawa Fort, Bikaner and the Gajner Palace of Sri Arvind Singh of Mewar.

Having run as the Palace on Wheels and Royal Orient Express in the past, the fully air-conditioned Heritage on Wheels comprises 14 coaches, including one restaurant and a bar lounge. The interiors are done in the traditional Gujarati style with 14 saloons and two dining pantry cars. The expansion of broad gauge had made this metre gauge train redundant and it was languishing in railway yards before being resurrected in 2006.

Chief Minister Vasundhara Raje, who backed the train's marketing, now wants the management to sell it in the form of "corporate meetings over getaway tourism", where executives can meet and also experience a sense of historical charm with modern conveniences. Go heritage! ■